

Understanding downgrade rights for purchasers

If you already have Windows 10 installed on your brand new hardware, and are wondering how to go back to an older, more-familiar version of Windows. There is still a way out.

If you buy Windows as part of your device, often you can avail of your downgrade rights. These allow you to opt for an older version of Windows

Client operating systems	Latest update or service pack	End of mainstream support	End of extended support
Windows XP	Service Pack 3	April 14, 2009	April 8, 2014
Windows Vista	Service Pack 2	April 10, 2012	April 11, 2017
Windows 7 *	Service Pack 1	January 13, 2015	January 14, 2020
Windows 8	Windows 8.1	January 9, 2018	January 10, 2023
Windows 10, released in July 2015 **	N/A	October 13, 2020	October 14, 2025

Windows lifecycle

in lieu of the one you get with the device. This offer is available for the previous two supported versions of Windows. So for Windows 10 devices, you can move back to Windows 8.1 or Windows 7.

This is harder than it need to be. You first need to install the previous version of Windows on your computer. For this you need the setup files of that previous version of Windows, and a product key. You can take this from a friend, or use a key you already have installed on another computer, or other less savoury sources. You can run the setup as normal using these files and the key.

Once Windows is installed activation will fail because you used a key that is already in use on another computer. At this point you will have to use manual phone activation, and tell them that you are exercising your downgrade rights, and they should help you with the activation.

Since you got Windows 10 with your computer in this case, you can easily upgrade to Windows 10 again later without needing to pay for an upgrade. Think of it this way, getting Windows 10 on a new computer entitles you to run Windows 7, Windows 8.1 or Windows 10 on that computer as long as you only run one at a time. 